

West were linked to one another by trade routes, campaigns, and wars. In each case, this led to the exchange of ideas, medicinal plants, and medical practices, including fertile connections between Ayurveda, Siddha, and traditional Chinese medicine to the east, and ancient Greek and Roman medicine to the west. Later, from around 700 CE, traditional Greek medicine, based on Hippocratic ideas, developed in the Arabic world as classical Greek texts were translated into Arabic. This tradition, known as Unani Tibb (meaning “Ionian medicine,” referring to the island of Iona where Hippocrates lived), at one time spanned from India to Spain, and is still the main form of herbal medicine practiced by hakims in the Middle East.



The chakras are represented in this figure. India's medical system, Ayurveda, identifies seven energy centers, chakras, sited along the spinal column from the head to the base of the spine. If they are blocked, illness results.

The Five Elements

Ayurveda is a unique holistic system, based on the interaction of body, mind, and spirit. In Ayurveda, the origin of all aspects of existence is pure intellect or consciousness. Energy and matter are one. Energy is manifested in five elements—ether, air, fire, water, and earth—which together form the basis of all matter. In the body, ether is present in the cavities of the mouth, abdomen, digestive tract, thorax, and lungs. Air is manifested in the movements of the muscles, pulsations of the heart, expansion and contraction of the lungs, and the workings of the digestive tract and the nervous system. Fire is manifested in the digestive system, metabolism, body temperature, vision, and intelligence. Water is present in the digestive juices, salivary glands, mucous membranes, blood, and cytoplasm. Earth exists in the nails, skin, and hair, as well as in the elements that hold the body together: bones, cartilage, muscles, and tendons.

The five elements manifest in the functioning of the five senses, and they are closely related to our ability to perceive and interact with the environment in which we live. In Ayurveda, ether, air, fire, water and earth correspond to hearing, touch, vision, taste, and smell respectively.

The Doshas & Health

The five elements combine to form three basic forces, known as the *tridoshas*, which exist in everything in the universe, and influence all mental and physical processes. From ether and air, the air principle *vata* is created; fire and water yield the fire principle *pitta*; and earth and water produce the water principle *kapha*. The principles correspond closely to the three humors of Tibetan medicine and somewhat resemble Galen's theory of the four humors (see p. 32).

According to Ayurveda, we are all born with a particular balance of *doshas*. The proportions are largely determined by the balance of *doshas* in our parents at the time of our conception. Our body type,

Nutmeg & mace (*Myristica fragrans*, p. 115) are different parts of the same tree. In India, nutmeg paste is applied to eczema, and mace is a warming herb for stomach infections.

Nutmeg

Mace

Holy basil (*Ocimum tenuifolium*, p. 116) is often planted in temple courtyards in India. It is used in Ayurvedic medicine to protect the heart, and recent research shows that it lowers blood pressure.

Fresh holy basil

Holy basil seeds

Balloon vine (*Cardiospermum* spp., p. 183) is used in Indian herbal medicine to bring on delayed menstruation.

Turmeric (*Curcuma longa*, p. 90) is a traditional Ayurvedic remedy for jaundice.